CHAPTER XIII

All the Days Between

Kolkata · 15 December 2024

“We spend our lives believing that the moments which change us will announce themselves, that love will find its language, and that every farewell will grant us the dignity of knowing it is the last. Yet some of the most enduring chapters of our lives unfold quietly between beginnings and endings that were never ours to decide. We mistake the ordinary for the everlasting, postpone the words we have carried for years, and trust that another evening will offer what this one could not. Only afterward do we understand how much of a lifetime can belong to a handful of unremarkable days —and how a single goodbye, spoken without the knowledge of its finality, can leave an entire history unfinished.”

On 7 December 2024, eight days before he was to see Sanondita again, Utkarsh sent her a message.

It was an ordinary invitation, written with the careful casualness of someone who had spent several minutes deciding how little he ought to say. Would she like to visit Eco Park on the fifteenth? They could walk around for a while, perhaps have dinner somewhere afterward. It had been so long since they had properly met.

He read the message twice before sending it.

There was nothing remarkable about the words. They contained no declaration, no suggestion that the evening might matter more than the many afternoons they had already spent together. Anyone reading them would have understood that two friends were arranging to meet.

That was precisely how he wanted them to appear.

He had imagined the evening differently.

There would be roses, though he had not yet decided where to buy them. There would be dinner at a restaurant more expensive than either of them had any sensible reason to visit. There would be conversations, laughter, and perhaps one of those small disagreements that had once made the hours inside their coaching classroom pass so pleasantly. And somewhere between the beginning of the evening and its end, he would finally tell her what he had spent so long finding reasons not to say.

Not because he expected an answer.

He no longer wished to persuade her of anything. He wanted to tell her what knowing her had meant to him, without making the evening depend on what she might say in return.

There were things he had never told her. He had carried them through the last months of coaching and the long intervals between their messages, imagining that they would be easier to say in person.

In ten days, he would leave Kolkata.

He had packed most of his belongings already. The room that had once seemed too small for his books, clothes, and accumulated disorder was beginning to look unfamiliar. There were empty spaces where ordinary things had stood for months, and the sight of them occasionally made him pause without knowing what he had stopped to remember.

He had come to Kolkata with ambitions that had little to do with Sanondita. He would leave with many of those ambitions still unfinished. The examination result had disappointed him; the city had exhausted him in ways he could not explain through a single failure. Leaving had become necessary long before he had found the courage to admit how much it would cost him.

Yet among all the things he was preparing to leave behind, there was one he could neither pack nor put away.

He had grown used to recognising her voice before looking up, to remembering her laughter after forgetting what he had said to

cause it. There had seemed no reason to explain such things while another morning together was still ordinary.

Perhaps he would on the fifteenth.

He imagined saying it plainly, without asking her to feel differently, without making her responsible for the years he had spent keeping it to himself. He imagined the relief of having finally spoken, of returning to his room afterward with nothing left to rehearse.

Whenever he imagined her listening, however, he found himself beginning the sentence again.

For the moment, there was only the invitation, the date he had chosen, and the small, unreasonable happiness of having something to look forward to.

On the morning of 15 December, he woke with the peculiar excitement of a person who had already lived an entire evening in his imagination and was now impatient for the real one to begin.

He had made plans for almost everything.

He had not yet bought the flowers.

The trouble began with the roses.

Utkarsh had always considered himself a reasonably practical person. He could spend hours working through a difficult mathematical problem, accept an examination result he disliked, and make decisions about his future with a degree of composure that occasionally surprised even him.

But on the afternoon of 15 December, standing outside a flower shop in Kolkata, he discovered that choosing a bouquet could defeat him more thoroughly than any examination he had ever attempted.

The first shop had roses, but no bouquets he particularly liked.

The second had bouquets, but the roses looked as though they had already endured several disappointments of their own.

At the third, he found himself explaining to a florist that he wanted something elegant, not excessively decorative, and certainly

not wrapped in the sort of bright paper that made a bunch of flowers resemble a prize at a school function.

The florist listened patiently.

“Red roses?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“How many?”

Utkarsh looked at the flowers.

He had not considered the number.

“Enough to make a proper bouquet.”

The florist waited.

“A good-sized one,” Utkarsh added, as though this clarified everything.

It did not.

Eventually, after examining several arrangements and rejecting most of them for reasons he could scarcely articulate, Utkarsh settled on a collection of red roses that seemed sufficiently beautiful to justify the trouble he had taken.

Then came the wrapping.

“Black paper,” he said.

The florist looked at him.

“And a golden ribbon.”

The man nodded and reached for a sheet of black wrapping paper.

“Not too much ribbon,” Utkarsh added.

The florist paused.

“But it should be visible.”

For a moment, neither spoke.

Utkarsh became conscious of how ridiculous he sounded.

“Just make it look nice,” he said at last.

The florist, who had probably been waiting for those words since the beginning of their acquaintance, returned to his work.

Utkarsh stood beside the counter, watching the roses disappear beneath careful folds of black paper.

He had imagined this part of the day many times.

In those imaginings, buying flowers had been a simple matter. He would enter a shop, choose a bouquet, pay for it, and arrive at Eco Park with enough time to stand near the entrance and pretend he had not been looking at the road every few seconds.

Reality, however, had developed an unfortunate interest in the details.

The ribbon was tied, untied, and adjusted. A rose near the edge leaned awkwardly outward, and Utkarsh asked whether it could be moved. The florist corrected it without complaint.

Then Utkarsh checked the time.

His stomach tightened.

He was already late.

Not a few minutes late. Not the kind of late that could be dismissed with a complaint about traffic and a sufficiently apologetic expression.

He was late enough that Sanondita would have been waiting for him.

He took the bouquet, paid hurriedly, thanked the florist, and stepped back into the street.

His phone was in his pocket.

He knew she might call. He knew, too, that there was no explanation he could offer that would make his delay seem particularly reasonable.

He had spent so long preparing something for her that he had neglected the simplest kindness of all.

Being there when he had promised.

The thought accompanied him through the journey.

He glanced repeatedly at the time, as though checking it often enough might persuade the minutes to return. Traffic moved with an indifference that seemed almost deliberate. At every delay, he looked down at the bouquet resting against his arm.

The roses were beautiful.

That was the most irritating part.

They looked exactly as he had wanted them to look.

He wondered whether she would like them.

Then he wondered whether she was angry.

Then, with a sudden embarrassment that made him turn towards the window, he wondered what she would think when she saw him arriving with flowers.

It had seemed such a natural idea when he was alone in his room.

A bouquet for her birthday.

Her birthday had been on 13 November.

More than a month earlier.

He had known this, of course. He had simply not considered how absurd the explanation might sound when spoken aloud.

He tried several versions in his head.

I couldn’t give you anything on your birthday.

That was true.

So I thought I’d give you something today.

Also true.

Happy birthday.

He looked at the roses.

Perhaps he should avoid that last part.

By the time he reached Eco Park, the afternoon had advanced considerably.

He stepped out and hurried towards the entrance, holding the bouquet carefully enough to protect the flowers while moving quickly enough to make the effort almost impossible.

Then he saw her.

Sanondita was standing near the entrance.

For an instant, the urgency of the journey disappeared beneath the simple astonishment of finding her there.

It was strange how often he had experienced that feeling.

He had seen her enter classrooms, turn corners, emerge from crowds, and look up from her phone. He knew her face. He knew the familiar manner in which she stood waiting, the expressions she wore when something amused or irritated her.

And still, after all those months, the sight of her could interrupt whatever he had been thinking.

She noticed him.

Her expression changed.

“How late are you, Utkarsh? I have been waiting here for an hour!”

There it was.

The welcome he deserved.

He reached her, slightly breathless, with the bouquet held awkwardly at his side.

“I know. I’m really sorry.”

“An hour!”

“I know.”

“What were you doing?”

He glanced at the flowers.

He could have told her.

He could have explained the shops, the wrapping paper, the ribbon, the unfortunate rose that had required repositioning, and the florist who had probably reconsidered his profession.

Instead, he offered another apology.

She looked at him with the exasperation of someone who had already spent too much of the afternoon waiting.

He had imagined greeting her with a smile, perhaps a clever remark, perhaps something sufficiently charming to make the beginning of their evening memorable.

He had not imagined standing before her like a schoolboy who had forgotten his homework.

And yet, as she complained and he attempted to defend himself with increasingly inadequate explanations, something familiar returned between them.

The ease of being ridiculous in her presence.

The small pleasure of knowing that she could be annoyed with him without their conversation becoming difficult.

He had missed that more than he had realised.

They moved towards the ticket counter.

Utkarsh reached for his wallet.

Sanondita stopped him.

“I’ll pay.”

“No, no. I’ll get the tickets.”

“I said I’ll pay.”

“Sanondita—”

But she was already taking care of it.

He stood beside her, holding the flowers and feeling faintly useless.

He had planned an elaborate evening. He had considered the restaurant, the bouquet, the things he might say, and the impression he hoped to leave behind.

He had not planned for her to buy their entrance tickets.

There was something almost comically appropriate about it.

For nearly two years, he had tried to arrange the smallest circumstances in ways that might bring him closer to her.

He had pretended to forget his phone.

He had pretended not to have an umbrella.

And now, on an evening he had prepared with more care than either of those earlier occasions, he had managed to arrive an hour late and lose an argument over two tickets.

Perhaps this was simply how things were meant to go whenever Sanondita was involved.

He followed her through the entrance.

The park opened before them, its paths stretching towards the lake, the late-afternoon light settling over the trees and the people moving between them.

The air carried the first noticeable coolness of the December evening.

For the moment, there was nowhere else he needed to be.

He had been counting the days until this meeting. Now that it had begun, he wanted the hours to become generous.

He adjusted the bouquet against his arm and fell into step beside her.

They walked a little farther.

Then, with a sudden and almost unbelievable embarrassment, he realised something.

He had forgotten to give her the flowers.

They had barely gone a few steps when Utkarsh stopped.

“Sanondita.”

She turned.

“What?”

He looked down at the bouquet in his hand.

He had arrived an hour late because of these flowers. Now he was carrying them through the park as though he had bought them for himself.

He held it out to her.

“This is for you.”

Sanondita looked at the roses, then at him.

“Is this really for me?”

The question was so sincere that he almost laughed.

Who else, he wondered, did she imagine he had brought them for?

But there was something unexpectedly touching about her surprise. For all the care he had taken in choosing the flowers, he had not prepared himself for the possibility that she might look at them as though receiving them were something extraordinary.

“Yes,” he said. “Of course.”

She accepted the bouquet carefully.

The red roses stood out against the black wrapping, the golden ribbon catching what remained of the afternoon light.

“Happy birthday,” he added.

She looked up.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then she laughed.

“My birthday?”

He immediately regretted his choice of words.

“Yes.”

“Utkarsh, my birthday was in November!”

“I know.”

“It’s December!”

“I know that too.”

She laughed again.

He had anticipated this difficulty during the journey, but anticipation had done remarkably little to improve his ability to explain himself.

“I couldn’t give you anything on your birthday,” he said. “So I thought I’d give you something today.”

She looked down at the roses once more.

“Oh.”

It was a small sound, almost lost beneath the conversations of people passing them.

Then she smiled.

“Thank you.”

He had been ready with explanations she had not asked for. Instead, he heard himself ask:

“You like them?”

“Yes. They’re beautiful.”

He looked at the flowers.

Until that moment, he had been concerned chiefly with whether they were beautiful enough.

Now, standing beside her, he found that the question had become irrelevant.

She liked them.

The florist’s patience, the wasted minutes, the hurried journey, even the embarrassment of arriving late—all of it seemed, for one brief and unreasonable instant, justified.

Then he remembered that she had waited an hour.

Perhaps not all of it.

They began walking.

Eco Park was alive with the pleasant disorder of a December afternoon. Families moved along the paths, children hurried ahead of their parents, and groups of friends stopped at intervals to take photographs. Across the lake, the declining sun laid a broad, trembling brightness upon the water.

The air had begun to cool.

Sanondita walked beside him with the bouquet held carefully against her arm. Every so often, she glanced at the roses, adjusting her grip when the wrapping slipped.

Utkarsh noticed each movement.

He wished he did not notice quite so much.

Her attention had already moved to the path ahead. He looked down at the roses once more before turning to see what she was pointing towards.

They followed a path beside the lake.

For a while, they talked about the journey, the traffic, and the extraordinary amount of time he had apparently needed to reach the park.

Sanondita was not prepared to let the matter go.

“One hour, Utkarsh.”

“You’ve mentioned that.”

“Because you were one hour late.”

“I was hoping you might eventually forget.”

“Why would I forget?”

“A generous nature?”

She turned towards him.

He looked solemnly ahead.

It took her a moment to laugh.

He had missed that laugh. Hearing it beside him again, he nearly answered with another joke before remembering how long it had been since they had walked together.

They walked a little farther before Sanondita looked up at him.

“Why are you so tall?”

Utkarsh glanced down.

It was not a question he had expected.

“I don’t know. I’ll ask my parents.”

She gave him a look.

“It’s awkward walking beside you.”

“Awkward?”

“Yes. I have to keep looking up.”

He considered this.

“Why didn’t you wear heels, then?”

“In this cold?”

He looked at her shoes.

“What does the cold have to do with heels?”

“Everything.”

“That explains it.”

She laughed.

He had no intention of winning the argument. He had discovered long ago that some conversations were more enjoyable when neither person made any serious attempt to be reasonable.

The path curved towards the water.

As they walked, the late sunlight thinned among the trees, and the first lamps along the pathway began to glow. Their reflections appeared in the lake as scattered points of gold, wavering whenever the breeze disturbed the surface.

They spoke of coaching.

It began naturally, with a question about whether either of them had heard from their old classmates.

Tanisha’s name came up, followed by Deepesh’s. They remembered the conversations that had made the classroom louder than it needed to be, the occasional absurdity of the lessons, and the small incidents that had seemed insignificant when they occurred.

Utkarsh found himself laughing at things he had not thought about for months. They remembered different parts of the same incidents. She supplied a name he had forgotten; he reminded her of an argument over an answer. For a few minutes, the old classroom seemed crowded again.

“Are you preparing properly now?” Sanondita asked.

He returned his attention to her.

“For CGL?”

“Yes.”

“Trying to.”

They talked about the examination.

He told her about the result, about missing the required marks by a narrow margin, and about the strange exhaustion of preparing for something that could consume months of effort before reducing them to a number.

He did not try to make the disappointment sound smaller than it was.

Neither did he dwell on it.

There would be another examination. There would be more preparation, more uncertainty, and perhaps another result he would have to learn to accept.

She listened.

He was grateful for that.

He had spent so much time associating her with his private disappointments that he sometimes forgot how simple it could be to speak to her about an ordinary one.

Then the conversation turned towards his departure.

“So you’re going home?”

“Yes.”

“When?”

“On the seventeenth.”

She looked at him.

“In two days?”

He nodded.

The date had become familiar to him. He had repeated it to himself while packing, while arranging the journey, while deciding which belongings were worth taking and which could be left behind.

Spoken aloud beside her, it sounded unexpectedly close.

“Will you miss Kolkata?” she asked.

He looked across the lake.

It was a difficult question.

There had been a time when he had liked the city without needing to explain why. He had liked its crowds, its unpredictable afternoons, the sense that something important might happen simply because so many lives were unfolding around him.

Later, the same streets had begun to exhaust him.

The disappointments had accumulated. His ambitions had become harder to sustain. Places he once visited willingly had acquired associations he did not always want to revisit.

He had begun to dislike Kolkata.

Sometimes he had thought he hated it.

But hatred was a poor description of what he felt now, standing beside a lake in the December light, with Sanondita carrying the flowers he had brought her.

He could leave the city.

He was not certain he could separate it from everything that had happened there.

“Yes,” he said.

She glanced at him.

“You’ll miss it?”

He nodded.

“Of course.”

It was not quite the answer he had expected to give.

But it was true.

He would miss streets he no longer wished to walk every day. He would miss the version of himself who had arrived there, and the people who had known him then.

Beside him, Sanondita adjusted the bouquet. In two days, arranging another evening like this would require more than choosing a date.

For a while, they walked without speaking.

It was not an uncomfortable silence.

There had been enough conversation between them over the years for silence to become another familiar thing.

Ahead, the pathway lights grew brighter as the evening settled over the park.

Sanondita adjusted the bouquet against her arm.

Utkarsh looked at the roses.

He wondered whether she would remember them.

Perhaps she would keep them for a few days. He hoped the roses would last long enough to open properly; some were still tight at the centre.

They continued along the lake.

Somewhere behind them, a child called out to a parent. A group of visitors passed, laughing over a photograph. The breeze lifted the edge of the black wrapping paper, and Sanondita pressed it gently back into place.

Utkarsh glanced at the time.

He was startled by how much of the afternoon had already passed.

For days, he had waited for the fifteenth to arrive.

Now that it had, the hours seemed almost unwilling to remain.

He put his phone away.

There would be time to look at it later.

For the moment, Sanondita was beside him, the lake was turning dark beneath the evening sky, and they were still in the middle of a conversation that neither had any particular reason to hurry.

Across the water, a group of young men were laughing loudly enough for the sound to reach them. Sanondita glanced towards the voices, then resumed what she had been saying.

Sanondita was telling him something about an old classmate.

He had been listening. At least, he believed he had.

Then she mentioned Deepesh, and he found himself remembering an afternoon in the coaching classroom when an argument over a question had continued long after anyone could remember what the original disagreement was about.

He laughed.

"What?" she asked.

"Nothing. I just remembered something."

"What?"

He told her.

She laughed too, though he suspected she remembered the incident rather differently.

"That wasn't what happened!"

"Of course it was."

"No!"

"Then I must have attended a different coaching centre."

She shook her head.

It was an old pleasure, being corrected by her.

He tried to remember the incident as she described it. Her version made him look considerably less reasonable than his own. He suspected that was why he had forgotten it.

They continued along the lakeside path.

The light had softened considerably. The water, bright and restless an hour earlier, was acquiring the darker colours of the evening sky. Lamps were coming on along the walkways, their reflections breaking into narrow, wavering lines whenever the breeze disturbed the surface.

Sanondita glanced at the bouquet.

"Are you sure you weren't supposed to give these to someone else?"

Utkarsh looked at her.

"Why?"

"Because you forgot to give them to me."

He laughed.

"I was distracted."

"By what?"

"Your extremely warm welcome."

She gave him a look.

"You were one hour late!"

“There it is again.”

“What?”

“The hour. I was beginning to think we’d finally left it behind.”

“You deserve to hear about it for the rest of the evening.”

“Only the evening? That’s generous.”

She laughed, and he found himself laughing with her.

He was still smiling when they passed beneath the next lamp. Later, he might forget which of them had said what. For now, she was beside him and the joke had not quite ended.

A boy approached them carrying several sticks of cotton candy.

The boy could not have been much older than fifteen. He held his colourful merchandise upright with the solemn determination of someone who had already decided that at least one of the people walking towards him would become a customer.

“Didi, cotton candy?”

Sanondita shook her head.

“No, thank you.”

The boy walked alongside them.

“Didi, take one.”

“No, no.”

“Just one, Didi.”

She smiled awkwardly and shook her head again.

Utkarsh watched the exchange with growing amusement.

The boy seemed to have identified Sanondita as the more promising customer. He directed every appeal towards her, barely acknowledging the tall young man walking beside her.

“Didi, please.”

Sanondita glanced at Utkarsh.

He was making a visible effort not to laugh.

“Why are you looking at me?” she asked.

“I’m not.”

“You are!”

“I was merely observing a business negotiation.”

She gave him an exasperated look.

The boy tried again.

“Didi, one?”

“No, I don’t want any.”

A man was standing a little farther along the path.

Sanondita gestured towards him.

“Ask that uncle over there.”

Utkarsh turned his head.

The man appeared entirely unaware that he had just been nominated as the solution to someone else’s difficulty.

For a second, Utkarsh managed to maintain a straight face.

Then he laughed.

Sanondita looked at him.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Why are you laughing?”

“Because that poor man hasn’t done anything.”

“So?”

“And now you’ve involved him.”

“He might want cotton candy!”

“Of course. He looks like he’s been waiting all evening for someone to offer him some.”

She began laughing too.

The boy looked between them, apparently uncertain whether the conversation had improved his chances of making a sale.

It had not.

Eventually, he moved away, carrying his bright collection towards another group of visitors.

Sanondita watched him go.

“He wouldn’t stop asking!”

“He recognised a valuable customer.”

“Why didn’t he ask you?”

Utkarsh considered the question.

“Perhaps I don’t look trustworthy.”

She laughed again.

“That’s probably true.”

He placed a hand against his chest.

“That was unnecessarily hurtful.”

“Good.”

He shook his head with exaggerated disappointment.

She was still smiling when they resumed walking.

He glanced back once. The boy had found another group to ask; the unsuspecting man stood where Sanondita had pointed him out. She caught Utkarsh looking and shook her head, smiling. They walked on.

They continued towards the illuminated structures farther inside the park.

The pathways were gradually becoming less crowded. Some families were making their way towards the exits, while others lingered beneath the lamps for photographs. The last traces of daylight remained above the trees, though the lake had already turned dark.

Ahead, the replica of the Eiffel Tower rose against the evening sky.

Its lights had come on.

Sanondita noticed it first.

“Look!”

He followed her gaze.

The structure glowed with a warm, pale brightness, its illuminated framework standing out against the deepening blue.

They turned towards it.

Beside him, Sanondita adjusted the bouquet. The golden ribbon caught the light of a nearby lamp.

He had meant to find a quiet moment to speak. Now that one had arrived, he followed her gaze towards the tower and let it pass.

The Eiffel Tower looked more beautiful from a distance.

Utkarsh had noticed this as they approached it. Against the darkening sky, its illuminated framework seemed almost delicate, a

structure made less of metal than of the warm white light passing through it. From nearby, however, its construction became visible: the intersecting beams, the spaces between them, the ordinary materials responsible for creating something that appeared extraordinary from across the park.

Sanondita stopped a little ahead of him.

“It’s beautiful!”

He looked towards the tower.

“Yes.”

She turned to him.

“Have you been here before?”

“Not recently.”

“It’s nice, isn’t it?”

“It is.”

She glanced around, taking in the lights, the remaining visitors, and the paths stretching away towards the lake.

The bouquet rested against her left arm, held in place by her right hand. The black wrapping had darkened beneath the evening sky, leaving the roses almost startlingly red whenever they passed beneath a lamp.

Utkarsh noticed that she was still carrying them carefully.

He had wondered, while buying the flowers, whether they might become inconvenient during a long walk. She had a phone to manage, a purse to carry, and now an entire bouquet that required more attention than he had anticipated.

He considered offering to hold it for a while.

Then he decided against it.

She seemed perfectly capable of carrying her own flowers.

They moved closer to the illuminated structure.

For a few moments, their conversation wandered between subjects without settling on any of them. They spoke about the park, about how much larger it seemed than Utkarsh remembered, and about whether the lights made it look better than it might have during the afternoon.

Then something occurred to him.
“Sanondita—”
At precisely the same moment, she said, “Utkarsh—”
They stopped.
“You go first,” he said.
“No, you.”
“Go on.”
“No, tell me.”
He waited.
She waited too.
For several seconds, neither made any attempt to speak.
Then she laughed.
“Just say it!”
“I was going to, but you interrupted.”
“I interrupted?”
“Yes.”
“You started talking when I did!”
“An unfortunate coincidence.”
She shook her head, still laughing.
“Fine. You say it.”
He looked at her.
The thought he had been about to express had vanished.
He tried to recover it.
Nothing came.
“What?” she asked.
He hesitated.
“I’ve forgotten.”
She stared at him.
Then she laughed harder.
“Seriously?”
“Yes.”
“You made me wait for that?”
“I didn’t know it would disappear.”

She lowered her head slightly, her shoulders moving with the effort of suppressing another laugh.

He knew that gesture.

He had seen it across classroom desks and over unfinished notebooks, sometimes after making a remark he had considered only moderately amusing. She would lower her face as though that might conceal the laughter, and the movement of her shoulders would betray her.

There had been mornings when he had said something foolish for no better reason than the possibility of seeing her do it.

He looked at her now.

The tower lights fell softly across her face.

For an instant, he waited for a teacher to interrupt them. The thought was so misplaced that it almost made him laugh again.

Then Sanondita straightened.

“What were you saying?”

“I genuinely don’t remember.”

“Wonderful.”

“What were you going to say?”

She paused.

“I’ve forgotten too.”

He turned towards her.

“You’re joking.”

“No!”

“Then why were you blaming me?”

“Because you started it!”

They both laughed.

They stood there with neither of their questions answered, laughing too much to recover them.

They walked around the tower.

The crowd had thinned. A few visitors stood near the illuminated framework taking photographs, while others moved slowly along the surrounding paths. Beyond the lights, the park was becoming

increasingly dark, its distant trees dissolving into the first suggestion of winter haze.

Sanondita stopped.

"Can you smell that?"

Utkarsh looked at her.

"Smell what?"

"That fragrance."

He drew a breath.

The air was cool. He could detect something faint from the nearby vegetation, perhaps the dampness of the lake carried by the breeze, but nothing that seemed particularly remarkable.

"What fragrance?"

She breathed in again.

"Something smells really nice."

He tried once more.

Nothing.

"Maybe it's the flowers," he suggested.

She lifted the bouquet towards her face and examined the roses.

"No."

"Are you sure?"

"Yes. It's not coming from these."

He looked around.

There were no obvious flowers nearby, no perfume shop, no visible source of the fragrance she seemed to have discovered.

"Perhaps someone walked past wearing perfume."

"Maybe."

She continued looking around for a moment, as though the answer might be waiting somewhere among the lights.

Utkarsh watched her.

Then an absurd thought occurred to him.

Perhaps that's what love smells like.

He nearly laughed at himself.

It was the kind of thought he would never have admitted aloud. Not because he believed it to be profound, but because he knew precisely how ridiculous it sounded.

He could not even smell it. His imagination, apparently, had decided that this was no obstacle.

He smiled.

Sanondita noticed.

“Why are you smiling?”

“Nothing.”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

She studied him for a second.

Then, apparently deciding that he was being strange again, she turned her attention back towards the tower.

He was grateful.

They had barely resumed walking when two young women approached them.

“Excuse me,” one said, looking towards Utkarsh. “Where is the Eiffel Tower?”

He stopped.

For a moment, he was uncertain whether he had heard correctly.

The illuminated structure rose only a short distance away.

Before he could answer, Sanondita turned towards the women.

“It’s right there,” she said, indicating the tower. “Just go that way.”

The women thanked her and continued along the path.

Utkarsh remained silent.

Sanondita looked at him.

“What?”

He glanced towards the tower.

“Nothing.”

“What happened?”

“They asked me.”

“So?”

“And you answered.”

She looked at him as though he had raised an objection too insignificant to deserve consideration.

“I knew where it was!”

“I knew too.”

“Then why didn’t you answer?”

“Because you answered first.”

She laughed.

He looked at the two women walking away.

Perhaps the women had wanted to know where the entrance was. He watched them go, still amused that Sanondita had answered so quickly.

Something else had returned to him.

A classroom.

A morning in March.

A girl he did not yet know, asking another girl what chapter the teacher was discussing.

Basavi had been sitting nearby.

The question had been addressed to her.

Utkarsh had answered instead.

He remembered the incident with an unexpected clarity.

At the time, he had not known Sanondita’s name. He had not known how she laughed, how she argued, what subjects she had studied, or how often she would eventually occupy his thoughts. He had known almost nothing about her beyond the fact that she had entered the classroom and, for reasons he could not have explained, made it difficult for him to concentrate on anything else.

She had asked Basavi a question.

He had answered.

Now, more than twenty-one months later, two strangers had addressed him, and Sanondita had answered before he could speak.

He smiled at the small reversal.

On that first morning, he had not even known her name. Now she was standing beside him with flowers he had bought her, and he still found himself uncertain how to begin a sentence.

He had not known that a stranger's question about a chapter could become the beginning of so much remembering.

And she, standing beside him now, had no particular reason to remember that first exchange as he did.

He wondered whether she remembered it at all.

He could have asked.

The question was simple enough.

Do you remember the first day we met?

But something held him back.

Perhaps he was afraid that she would say no.

Or perhaps he understood that the memory did not require her confirmation to remain real.

He remembered the question and his own unnecessary answer. Whatever she remembered, he did not have to surrender that small beginning.

"Utkarsh?"

He looked at her.

"Hmm?"

"Where are you lost?"

"Nowhere."

"You've become very quiet."

"Have I?"

"Yes."

He smiled.

"I'm thinking."

"About what?"

He glanced towards the tower.

"Something from coaching."

"What?"

He considered telling her.

He could have described that first morning, the question addressed to Basavi, his unnecessary answer, and the strange amusement of finding themselves in the opposite positions so much later.

It would have been harmless.

She might even have laughed.

Instead, he said, “I’ll tell you later.”

She gave him a mildly suspicious look.

“Fine.”

Then she began walking again.

He followed.

The tower stood behind them, still illuminated, while the last of the evening light disappeared from the sky.

He had said later so readily. There was still dinner; the evening still seemed to have somewhere to go.

Beside him, Sanondita was looking at the lights, the bouquet resting against her arm.

He wanted to tell her that she looked beautiful.

The thought came without expectation, without any desire to discover what she might say in return.

He could have spoken it as an ordinary compliment.

Instead, he watched her for another moment.

Then he looked ahead.

There was still dinner.

There would be another opportunity.

And so, once again, he left the words where they had always been.

With himself.

By the time they returned towards the lake, the park had begun to empty.

The change was gradual enough that Utkarsh had not noticed it at first. The conversations that had accompanied them throughout the afternoon were becoming less frequent. Families were gathering

their belongings, children were being persuaded to leave, and the distant laughter that had once seemed to come from every direction had thinned into occasional voices along the pathways.

The last colour had disappeared from the western sky.

A pale mist was beginning to gather over the water.

Utkarsh glanced at his phone.

It was not yet seven.

He had known that the afternoon would end. He had known it while choosing the flowers, while travelling towards Eco Park, and even while standing before Sanondita with an apology that could scarcely account for his lateness.

But knowing that time was passing had done nothing to prepare him for how little of it seemed to remain.

He put his phone away.

Sanondita was walking beside him, the bouquet resting against her left arm. He had folded his jacket over his own left forearm earlier, finding the evening cool but not yet cold enough to wear it.

For a while, they spoke about nothing particularly memorable.

He asked whether she was tired.

“No. Why?”

“We’ve been walking for quite a while.”

“So?”

“Nothing. Just asking.”

She looked at him.

“Are you tired?”

He considered the question.

His legs were perfectly comfortable.

“No,” he said.

They walked another few steps.

Then he noticed a small black iron bench near the lake.

It stood a little apart from the main pathway, beneath a streetlamp whose yellow-white light fell across the ground and reached towards the water. Beyond it, the lake was darkening

beneath the mist, its surface disturbed only occasionally by the breeze.

Utkarsh looked at the bench.

Then at Sanondita.

“My legs are hurting a little,” he said.

She stopped.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“Then let’s sit.”

He nodded with what he hoped was a sufficiently convincing expression of relief.

They walked towards the bench.

It was his third lie.

The first had been about a forgotten phone.

He had pretended to leave it behind so that he could share the PDF on her phone and sit closer. Asking for her number had come later, after they had finally begun talking. All that invention, when he might simply have asked to sit beside her.

The second had been about an umbrella.

He had possessed one. He had chosen not to admit it because walking beside her through the rain had seemed preferable to remaining dry.

And now, after all the months that had passed, after everything he had learned about the difference between affection and expectation, he had invented an aching pair of legs because he wanted to sit beside her for a little longer.

He almost laughed.

Two years of growing older, studying, failing examinations, making difficult decisions, and attempting to become a more sensible person had apparently done very little to improve his honesty in matters involving Sanondita.

He simply did not want to leave the park yet.

They sat.

Sanondita took the left side of the bench.

Utkarsh settled on her right, placing his folded jacket carefully across his lap.

For a moment, he was occupied with the ordinary business of making himself comfortable. He adjusted the jacket, moved slightly to allow her enough room, and glanced towards the pathway to see whether they were obstructing anyone.

Then he looked at her.

The streetlamp stood a few feet to his right. Its light reached across the bench and illuminated the right side of Sanondita's face, leaving the other side in the softer shadows of the evening.

The effect was gentle rather than dramatic.

He could see the familiar outline of her glasses, the small movements of her expression as she looked towards the lake, and the loose strands of hair that had escaped their arrangement during the afternoon.

The bouquet lay against her arm.

She seemed comfortable.

He hoped she was.

For a few seconds, neither spoke.

Utkarsh looked ahead.

It was astonishing how little a person needed in order to remember an entire period of life.

A bench.

A place beside someone.

The knowledge that, for the moment, there was no need to move.

He had sat beside Sanondita hundreds of times.

There had been classroom chairs with narrow writing tablets that seemed designed to make a tall person uncomfortable, and benches with notebooks spread between them. Whatever the room, they had found ways to negotiate how much space each required.

Sometimes she had arrived first. He remembered entering and finding her already settled, her notebook open. There had been nothing to arrange, nothing to ask beyond whether she had solved the question. He had not known how much he would miss that ease.

Sanondita shifted slightly.

“It’s nice here.”

He looked towards the lake.

“Yes.”

The water reflected the lights from the opposite bank in long, broken lines. The mist was becoming more visible, softening the outlines of trees and distant structures.

A few visitors passed behind them.

Someone was calling to a child farther along the path.

Otherwise, the evening was quiet.

He had imagined himself speaking at dinner, then returning to his room with nothing left to rehearse. On the bench, he found himself content to delay even that relief. Sanondita was looking across the water. He could remain beside her without making her turn towards him.

He glanced at her.

She was looking across the lake.

He wondered what she was thinking about.

Perhaps the dinner they had yet to choose.

Perhaps the time.

Perhaps nothing in particular.

He did not know.

He turned his attention back towards the water.

For a while, they remained silent.

Then Sanondita spoke.

“The park closes at seven, you know.”

He looked at her.

“What?”

“Seven. They close the park at seven.”

He glanced towards the darkening pathways.

“Really?”

“Yes.”

He checked his phone again.

The remaining minutes were fewer than he had expected.

“Oh.”

She looked at him.

“You didn’t know?”

“No.”

“Then what was your plan?”

He considered this.

“Apparently, to stay here until someone asked us to leave.”

She laughed.

He smiled, but the amusement faded more quickly than he expected.

Seven. He looked at the time again, then put the phone away. The number would only change in one direction.

He looked at the lake.

“Sanondita?”

“Hmm?”

“Why don’t we go to coaching again?”

She turned towards him.

“What?”

“Coaching. Why don’t we start going again?”

The question had escaped before he had properly considered it.

He had not meant to ask it.

Or perhaps he had been asking it silently for months.

She seemed to take the suggestion seriously.

“We can,” she said. “They said we could keep attending until we clear the exam, remember?”

“Yes.”

“So we can go again.”

He nodded.

She was right.

There was no practical obstacle that needed to be discussed. The institute had offered continued classes, and if they wished, they could return.

But he had not really been asking about the institute.

He had been thinking of the old classroom, of the morning light through its windows, of arriving with a notebook and finding her already seated.

He had been thinking of a time when seeing her tomorrow had required no arrangement beyond attending the next lesson.

He wanted to return to that simplicity.

Not to begin the story again.

Not to change what had happened.

Only to spend another morning inside a life that had ended so quietly he had scarcely recognised its departure.

He knew, even as the thought formed, that returning to the building would not restore it.

The classmates had moved on.

Their routines had changed.

He was leaving Kolkata in two days.

The chairs might still be there. The teacher might still be explaining the same kinds of questions. Someone might even occupy the places they had once preferred.

But the mornings he wanted were no longer waiting inside that room.

They existed only where all completed days eventually went.

“Leave it,” he said.

Sanondita looked at him.

“What?”

“Nothing. Leave it.”

She did not press him.

He was grateful, though he could not have explained what he was grateful for.

The conversation drifted elsewhere.

A breeze passed over the lake, lifting the edge of the black wrapping around the roses.

Sanondita adjusted it.

Utkarsh looked at her hands. He remembered the neat working in her notebook and how often he had leaned across to check an

answer. He wondered which of those mornings she remembered, then turned back towards the lake.

Sanondita looked towards the pathway.

"We should probably go soon."

"Yes."

Neither stood immediately.

For a little while longer, they remained on the bench.

The park continued emptying around them.

A couple passed beneath the streetlamp. Somewhere beyond the trees, a child protested against leaving. The distant sound of footsteps gradually faded.

Utkarsh glanced at Sanondita.

She was sitting on his left, just as she had sat beside him on so many mornings that now seemed impossibly far away.

He knew how much room to leave, when to turn towards her. He had learned these things without noticing. Now he straightened the jacket on his lap and tried not to watch the time.

She knew he was leaving Kolkata.

She did not know that he had come to this meeting believing it might be the last occasion on which they would see each other.

She had come to spend an evening with him. He was glad she seemed comfortable, and afraid of how quickly that might change if he explained why the bench mattered.

So he said nothing.

He looked towards the lake.

The water was almost black now, except where the lights trembled across its surface.

He thought of all the mornings he had spent beside her, certain that there would be another.

He looked at the stretch of bench beyond his right hand, then back at the water. Soon the place on his left would be empty too. He had spent months without seeing her; he knew he could do it. That knowledge offered little help while she was still here.

He lowered his gaze.

His jacket lay folded across his lap.

He straightened one of its sleeves, though there was nothing wrong with it.

Sanondita was saying something about the time.

He listened.

Then he answered her, and the conversation continued.

It was important that it continued.

He did not want the evening to become a farewell before it had to.

For a few minutes more, they were simply Utkarsh and Sanondita, sitting beside a lake in December, talking as they always had.

And because he knew how little time remained, he found himself wishing, with a tenderness almost too quiet to recognise, that he had never learned to count the hours at all.

“So,” Utkarsh said, “where shall we have dinner?”

Sanondita turned towards him.

“Didn’t you already decide?”

“I decided we should have dinner. The location remains open to discussion.”

“Very organised.”

“Thank you.”

“That wasn’t a compliment.”

“I’ve decided to accept it as one.”

She laughed.

They were still sitting on the black iron bench beside the lake. The light from the streetlamp had grown more pronounced as the evening darkened, falling across Sanondita’s face and the roses resting against her arm.

Utkarsh adjusted the jacket on his lap.

“I was thinking of Marriott.”

She looked at him.

“Marriott?”

“Yes.”

“The hotel?”

“I don’t know of another Marriott nearby.”

“Utkarsh!”

“What?”

“Why would we go there?”

“For dinner. That was the general idea.”

She stared at him for a moment, then shook her head.

“No. Absolutely not.”

“Why?”

“Because it’s expensive!”

He shrugged.

“We can manage.”

“We?”

“Yes. A very small organisation consisting of two people.”

“Neither of whom has a job!”

He laughed.

“That is an unfortunate detail.”

“An important detail!”

“I agree it’s worth mentioning.”

She gave him a look that suggested he was being deliberately unreasonable.

He was.

He had known she might object. He had considered several restaurants during the week, compared their menus, and tried to imagine where she would feel comfortable. Marriott had appealed to him partly because he wanted the evening to be special and partly because he had never taken her anywhere quite like it.

He had not thought very carefully about whether she would enjoy an expensive dinner.

He had thought about whether he could afford one.

They were not the same question.

“Seriously,” she said, “why spend so much?”

“It’s just one dinner.”

“That’s exactly why you shouldn’t spend so much.”

He smiled.

She was not angry. There was a practical firmness in her voice, the same quality he remembered from conversations in which she had dismissed some unnecessarily elaborate plan of his with a few perfectly reasonable objections.

He could have insisted.

He could have told her that he had saved enough, that the expense would not trouble him, that he was leaving Kolkata in two days and wanted to do something memorable before he went.

But she had already said she did not want to go. He closed the listing and let the objection stand.

"Fine," he said. "Not Marriott."

"Good."

"Your decision has been recorded."

"Thank you."

"Against the recommendation of the management."

She laughed.

"Your management is terrible."

"I'll inform the management."

"You do that."

He took out his phone.

"Then where?"

She considered.

"Let's look."

He opened a list of restaurants he had saved.

She leaned slightly towards the screen.

For a moment, he was reminded of their coaching days, when she would look at a question in his notebook and ask why he had approached it in such an unnecessarily complicated way.

The resemblance amused him.

There he was again, presenting a selection of options for Sanondita to examine, prepared to defend choices that had already begun to seem less sensible under her scrutiny.

They scrolled through photographs of dining rooms, menus, and dishes whose names required more concentration than either of them wished to devote to dinner.

“This one?” he asked.

She looked.

“No.”

“Why?”

“Too expensive.”

“You haven’t even seen the prices.”

“I can tell.”

“An extraordinary talent.”

“Next.”

He scrolled.

“What about this?”

She studied the photograph.

“Maybe.”

“That’s progress.”

“Show me the menu.”

He opened it.

They examined the dishes.

Some were familiar. Others came with descriptions so elaborate that Utkarsh suspected the restaurant had employed someone specifically to make ordinary ingredients sound mysterious.

He read one aloud.

Sanondita frowned.

“What is that?”

“I was hoping you’d know.”

“You chose the restaurant!”

“I chose a photograph of the restaurant. The food remains a separate investigation.”

She laughed.

He scrolled farther.

“Apparently, this is served with something called a reduction.”

“A reduction of what?”

“Possibly the customer’s bank balance.”

She burst out laughing.

He was pleased with himself.

It had been a good line.

He made a private note not to repeat it, since doing so would almost certainly ruin it.

They continued searching.

Then Sanondita pointed towards another result.

“What about Babylon Lounge?”

He opened the listing.

Photographs filled the screen: a softly lit interior, greenery arranged overhead, tables set beneath warm lights, and a menu offering enough variety to satisfy two people who had not yet agreed on what they wanted to eat.

“This looks nice,” she said.

He examined it.

“It does.”

“And it’s not Marriott.”

“A serious advantage, apparently.”

She smiled.

“Let’s go here.”

“Babylon Lounge it is.”

“Are you sure?”

“Of course.”

“You don’t have to agree just because I said it.”

He looked at her.

“I suggested Marriott. You rejected Marriott. We’ve now discovered somewhere we both like. That sounds suspiciously like a successful discussion.”

She laughed.

“Fine.”

He checked the location.

They would need a cab after leaving the park.

He could arrange that.

He checked the route, then handed her the phone again. Choosing a restaurant had given him something he could ask plainly and receive an answer to.

He looked at Sanondita.

She was studying the menu on his phone.

“Look at this,” she said.

He leaned closer.

“What?”

“This dish.”

He read its name.

“Do you want that?”

“Maybe.”

“You’ve said maybe to everything.”

“I’m deciding.”

“At this rate, we’ll be ordering breakfast.”

She laughed.

He watched her scroll.

For several minutes, they discussed food with an earnestness that would have been difficult to justify to anyone who knew how rarely people ordered exactly what they had planned.

It was pleasant.

He had imagined that a final meeting ought to be filled with important conversations.

Instead, he was sitting beside her, examining pictures of dishes they might not eat.

He was enjoying himself. He had spent the week trying to arrange the evening, and now she was changing it, dismissing one option and showing him another. He leaned closer to see the dish she meant.

He looked towards the lake.

The mist had thickened slightly.

Beyond the nearest lights, the water and the opposite bank seemed to be moving farther apart, though he knew nothing had changed except the visibility.

He thought about the restaurant she had refused.

There was a time when Marriott would have seemed almost impossibly expensive to him. Even now, the prospect of paying for dinner there required consideration. Perhaps one day he would have a secure job and enough money to visit such places without thinking twice.

Perhaps he would pass the examination.

Perhaps the failure that had seemed so devastating ten days earlier would become little more than an unpleasant memory.

He hoped so.

But something about that imagined future troubled him.

He had always assumed that the things he could not afford today would be waiting for him when he finally could.

A better restaurant.

A more comfortable life.

A journey postponed until there was enough money.

He had believed that success would give him the means to recover the experiences he had missed while working towards it.

Now, sitting beside Sanondita, he wondered whether that was entirely true.

There would be restaurants in the future.

There would be evenings when he could order without checking the prices, when a bill would no longer require calculation, when the thought of an expensive dinner might seem ordinary.

But those evenings would belong to whoever he had become by then.

They could not be exchanged for this one.

He might return to Eco Park years later, better dressed, more successful, with no examination hanging over his future and no departure waiting two days away.

He might even sit on this same bench.

But he could not purchase the presence of the people who had once sat beside him.

He could not recover the precise sound of Sanondita laughing at his jokes, or the sight of her examining a restaurant menu while holding a bouquet of roses against her arm.

And he could not know whether the things he desired so intensely now would still matter to him when he finally possessed the means to obtain them.

Perhaps some desires faded because they had been fulfilled.

Others faded because the life in which they had mattered had quietly ended.

He looked down at his phone.

The menu was still open.

Sanondita was pointing towards another dish.

“Does this look good?”

He brought his attention back to the screen.

“Yes.”

“You haven’t even looked!”

“I was looking.”

“At the lake!”

“The lake is very beautiful.”

“We’re choosing dinner!”

“My apologies.”

She shook her head.

“Focus.”

He laughed.

“Yes, ma’am.”

She continued examining the menu.

He looked at her for a moment longer.

He was glad they had chosen somewhere together. On the screen, Babylon Lounge was still only a photograph; she had already given him a reason to remember choosing it.

A faint crackle sounded from a loudspeaker somewhere along the pathway.

They both looked up.

An announcement followed, informing visitors that the park would be closing and requesting everyone to proceed towards the exits.

Sanondita glanced at him.

“See? I told you.”

He looked towards the speaker.

“A little unnecessary, announcing it to the entire park just to prove you right.”

She laughed.

“Come on. We should go.”

“Yes.”

But he did not stand immediately.

He looked at the lake once more.

The black surface held the scattered reflections of the lamps. The mist had softened the opposite bank, and the remaining visitors were making their way along the path behind them.

He could still tell her that he was glad she had come. He glanced towards her, but she was gathering the bouquet, preparing to stand.

Instead, he stood.

Sanondita rose beside him, adjusting the bouquet.

He folded his jacket over his left arm again.

They began walking towards the exit.

For a few steps, he looked back.

The bench was empty.

There was nothing remarkable about it.

It was a small black iron bench beside a lake, beneath a streetlamp that would continue shining long after the park had closed.

Tomorrow, someone else would sit beneath that lamp. He looked once more at the place her bouquet had occupied, then turned away.

Sanondita was waiting a few steps ahead.

“Coming?”

“Yes.”

He caught up with her.

They walked towards the gates, the remaining lights of Eco Park shining behind them.

He had postponed the conversation again.

He knew it.

But dinner was still ahead.

They would sit together at another table, perhaps laugh at something neither had anticipated, perhaps find a quieter moment when the words would come more easily.

There was no reason to make the walk towards the exit unnecessarily serious.

He would tell her after dinner.

The decision comforted him.

And because it comforted him, he did not examine it too closely.

Outside the park, the December air felt cooler.

Utkarsh opened his phone and booked a cab to Babylon Lounge.

They waited near the entrance while vehicles passed along the road and the lights of the park receded behind the gates.

When the cab arrived, he checked the registration number, approached the rear door, and opened it for her.

Sanondita looked at him with a small, amused expression.

“Thank you.”

“You’re welcome.”

She climbed inside, carefully drawing the bouquet after her.

He closed the door and walked around to the other side.

For a moment, before getting in, he glanced back towards the park.

He could no longer see the bench.

He could not even tell exactly where it stood.

Then he opened the door and took his seat beside her.

The driver confirmed their destination.

Utkarsh answered.

The cab pulled away.

He had left the park without saying what he had come to say.

But he was still beside her.

And for the moment, that seemed reason enough to believe the evening had not yet begun to end.

The cab moved slowly through the evening traffic.

Beyond the window, Kolkata was beginning to resemble the city Utkarsh knew best: shopfronts illuminated against the darkness, headlights gathering at intersections, pedestrians crossing between vehicles with an assurance he had never entirely acquired, and the familiar, impatient chorus of horns rising whenever the traffic stopped.

December had brought a gentler cold to the streets.

Inside the cab, the windows were closed, and the air carried the faint, unfamiliar scent of the upholstery. The driver had turned on the radio at a volume low enough that neither passenger could make out the words.

Sanondita sat to Utkarsh's left.

The bouquet rested across her lap, its black wrapping gathered carefully beneath the roses. Every so often, she adjusted it to keep the flowers from pressing against the door.

Utkarsh placed his folded jacket beside him.

He glanced at the route on his phone.

The restaurant was not far, though the traffic suggested that distance would have very little influence on their arrival time.

He put the phone away.

For a while, they said nothing.

It was not an uncomfortable silence, at least not initially. They had spent enough time together to know that conversation did not always require continuous effort. There had been long stretches in the coaching classroom when neither had spoken, when one of them had been solving a question and the other had been reading, and the quiet had seemed entirely natural.

But this was different.

The classroom had always provided something to return to.

A teacher would begin speaking. Someone would ask a question. A notebook would be passed across a desk. The silence would end without either of them needing to decide how.

In the cab, there was only the road ahead.

Utkarsh looked towards the window.

A motorcycle passed close to them, its rider wearing a dark jacket. For an instant, the red light from a nearby shop travelled across the side of the helmet before the vehicle disappeared into traffic.

He remembered a name.

Nayan.

He had not intended to think about him that evening.

He knew they had broken up, and he remembered how still she had been in the classroom that March morning. He had not wanted to ask about it then. Now, with the road passing outside and dinner still ahead, a question returned that he had never quite put away.

It concerned a date.

He had remembered it because it was her birthday.

The thirteenth of November.

He turned towards her.

“Sanondita?”

“Hmm?”

“Can I ask you something?”

She looked up from the bouquet.

“What?”

He hesitated.

It was not a question that belonged naturally to a cheerful evening. He could have left it alone, and perhaps he should have. Yet the silence of the cab had made him aware of how many things he had accepted without ever understanding them.

“It’s about Nayan.”

Her expression changed slightly.

Not enough for him to know what she was thinking.

He continued before the question could become more difficult.

“Did he propose to you on your birthday?”

She looked at him.

“Yes.”

He nodded.

“Thirteenth November, 2023?”

She shook her head.

“No. That was when I accepted.”

Utkarsh turned fully towards her.

“What?”

“When I accepted,” she repeated.

He stared at her for a moment.

“Then when did he propose?”

“Thirteenth November, 2022.”

He said nothing.

She seemed to consider the matter straightforward.

“He proposed on my birthday in 2022,” she explained. “I accepted a year later, on my birthday in 2023.”

“A year later?”

“Yes.”

He looked at her.

“A whole year?”

She gave a small smile.

“Yes, Utkarsh. A year.”

He almost asked why.

Then he stopped himself.

It was not his question to ask.

He knew only that Nayan had expressed his feelings and that Sanondita had taken a year before deciding to accept them. Whatever had happened during that time—whatever conversations, doubts, hopes, or changes of heart had belonged to it—was not something he could reconstruct from two dates.

She added, almost casually, “He wrote me a letter.”

Utkarsh listened.

“And he made a portrait of me.”

“A portrait?”

“Yes.”

He looked at her with genuine surprise.

“He drew you?”

She nodded.

He considered this.

“A letter and a portrait?”

“Yes.”

“That’s quite an effort.”

She smiled faintly.

He looked ahead.

He could not deny that it was.

He pictured the letter beside the portrait. He had spent so long choosing a sentence for her birthday note; he could imagine something of the hesitation before giving her either of these things. Beyond that, he knew nothing about the young man who had made them.

Nor did he need to.

He turned back towards the window.

The cab stopped at a traffic signal.

A pedestrian crossed in front of them carrying a large shopping bag. The driver adjusted the radio. Somewhere behind them, a horn sounded twice.

Ordinary things continued happening.

Utkarsh hardly noticed.

Thirteenth November, 2022.

Thirteenth November, 2023.

He repeated the dates silently.

They were separated by exactly one year.

He had known the second date.

Or rather, he had believed he knew what it meant.

He had thought of November 2023 as the beginning of something between Sanondita and Nayan, a boundary after which the possibilities he had once imagined no longer belonged to him.

He had not known that the story had begun a year earlier.

Before he had ever entered that classroom.

Before he had learned her name.

Before the morning in March when she had asked Basavi about a chapter and he had answered instead.

The traffic light changed.

The cab began moving again.

Utkarsh looked down at his hands.

He remembered the seventh of March, 2023.

He remembered arriving at coaching, the unfamiliar faces, the ordinary uncertainty of beginning something new.

He remembered seeing Sanondita.

He remembered how little he had understood about the person who would eventually become so important to him.

At that very moment, somewhere beyond his knowledge, another young man had already told her that he loved her.

The thought unsettled him.

A proposal was not a promise. He could not know what the year had been like for her simply because he now knew its dates.

What troubled him was the discovery that the beginning of his own story had taken place in the middle of another story he had never known existed.

He had entered her life during a year in which a question had already been asked and its answer had not yet been given.

All those mornings.

The lessons.

The conversations.

The day he had contrived an excuse to share her phone.

The rain.

The walks.

The laughter that had followed him home.

They had happened between those two birthdays.

Between a proposal and its acceptance.

He had never known.

For months, he had remembered that period as the time before Nayan.

Now he understood that it had not been before.

It had simply been a time when he knew nothing about him.

The distinction was small in language and immense in feeling.

Utkarsh leaned back against the seat. The dates changed what he knew about those months. They could not tell him what she had felt on an afternoon when she had laughed beside him, or what she had carried home after class.

He had been her friend. She had been his. That remained, even as the boundaries he had drawn around their story became less certain.

He looked at her.

She was adjusting the golden ribbon around the bouquet.

The flowers had survived the long walk remarkably well.

He noticed that one of the outer petals had bent slightly against the wrapping.

He considered telling her.

Then decided it did not matter.

“Utkarsh?”

He looked up.

“What?”

“You’ve gone quiet again.”

He smiled.

“Have I?”

“Yes.”

“I’m thinking.”

“Again?”

“It’s a serious problem.”

She laughed softly.

“What are you thinking about?”

He looked towards the window.

He could hardly tell her that he was trying to place two dates among memories he had thought he knew by heart.

And he did not want to burden her with any of it.

“Nothing important,” he said.

She looked at him for a moment.

Then she turned back towards the window.

He watched the lights move across her glasses.

He wondered whether she would ever know how much of his life had been shaped by the days she had spent beside him.

Perhaps not.

Perhaps she would remember him as a friend from coaching, someone who had made her laugh, someone who had occasionally behaved foolishly and once arrived an hour late carrying birthday flowers a month after her birthday.

He hoped she would remember him kindly.

That was enough to wish for.

The cab slowed again.

Utkarsh checked the route.

They were approaching the restaurant.

He could see brighter streets ahead, buildings decorated for December, and the occasional suggestion of Christmas in shop windows and strings of lights.

Sanondita leaned forward slightly to look outside.

“Are we almost there?”

“Yes.”

“Good. I’m getting hungry.”

He laughed.

“After examining approximately forty-seven menus, I should hope so.”

“It wasn’t forty-seven!”

“Forty-six, then.”

She laughed again.

He put his phone away.

For a moment, he wanted to ask why she had waited a year. Then she leaned towards the window to look at the decorations, and he let the question remain unasked. He had no wish to spend the rest of their journey trying to reconstruct a relationship from which he had been absent.

He thought of the boy he had been in March 2023, pleased because a stranger had spoken within reach of him. He would not have wanted to take those months away from that boy. He wished only that he could remember them without having to decide what they had made possible.

The cab moved past another string of lights. Sanondita was hungry. Dinner was still ahead.

The cab came to a halt.

"We're here," the driver said.

Utkarsh looked outside.

Babylon Lounge.

Sanondita gathered her purse and bouquet.

He reached for his jacket.

The door opened, and the cold December air entered the cab.

He stepped out.

For a brief moment, he stood beside the vehicle, waiting for her.

Then Sanondita emerged, carefully bringing the flowers with her.

She looked towards the entrance.

"Shall we?"

He nodded.

"Yes."

She began walking.

He followed, then caught up with her.

There was dinner to be had, and a conversation he had promised himself he would begin. He looked at the roses against her arm, then followed her through the entrance.

By the time they entered Babylon Lounge, it was nearly eight.

The warmth inside came as a pleasant relief from the December air. Utkarsh paused just beyond the entrance, allowing his eyes a moment to adjust to the softer lighting.

The restaurant was beautiful.

Greenery hung from the ceiling in carefully arranged clusters, descending above tables illuminated by small, warm lights. Beyond the dining area, a broad glass wall reflected the interior, mingling the figures of guests with the darkness outside. Christmas decorations had been placed throughout the room: delicate ornaments suspended among the leaves, small arrangements of red and gold, and a decorated tree near one corner.

It was festive without being overwhelming.

Sanondita stopped beside him.

“Oh, this is nice!”

Utkarsh looked around.

“Yes. It really is.”

She turned towards him.

“See? I chose well.”

“You did.”

“Better than Marriott.”

“We haven’t eaten yet.”

She laughed.

“Still!”

He nodded solemnly.

“I’ll reserve my final judgment until the food arrives.”

“Fine.”

A member of the staff approached them and asked whether they had a reservation.

Utkarsh explained that they did not.

After a brief conversation, they were shown to a table near the glass wall.

Sanondita walked ahead, carrying the bouquet.

Utkarsh followed.

Four long stools stood around the table, two on either side. From where he stood, he could see the Christmas tree and much of the dining area.

He folded his jacket and set it on the unused stool across the table.

Sanondita set her purse down and looked around once more.

“I like this place.”

“Good.”

“Really.”

“Then the restaurant-selection committee has succeeded.”

She laughed.

“Stop calling it that!”

“I believe the committee deserves recognition.”

“The committee was me.”

“Exactly. A remarkably efficient organisation.”

She shook her head, smiling.

They sat.

For a moment, Utkarsh looked across the table at her.

The width of a table between them.

An ordinary arrangement that had somehow become unfamiliar.

During their coaching days, they had so often sat beside each other that facing her across a table felt almost formal.

He looked towards the empty stool beside him.

Then at Sanondita.

“Why don’t you sit here?”

She glanced up.

“Where?”

“Beside me.”

“Why?”

He considered the question.

“Old habit.”

She smiled.

“What old habit?”

“Coaching. We always sat beside each other.”

“Not always!”

“Frequently enough to establish a tradition.”

She laughed.

“A tradition?”

“A respected one.”

She shook her head again.

But after a moment, she stood, gathered her purse, and moved to the stool beside him.

“There. Happy?”

“Very.”

She gave him an amused look.

He smiled.

He shifted a little to give her room. From this side of the table they could both see the Christmas tree, though she had to turn slightly to look at it.

A waiter brought the menus.

Sanondita opened hers immediately.

Utkarsh did the same.

For several minutes, they examined the dishes with the seriousness of people who had already spent a considerable portion of the evening deciding where to eat and were now discovering that the difficult decisions had only begun.

“What are you having?” she asked.

“I haven’t decided.”

“Same.”

“We’ve made excellent progress.”

She laughed.

He turned a page.

There were elaborate descriptions, unfamiliar preparations, and photographs of dishes arranged so carefully that he suspected eating them would constitute an act of vandalism.

He pointed towards one.

“What about this?”

She leaned closer.

“What is it?”

He read the description.

She considered it.

“No.”

“Why?”

“I don’t know.”

“A compelling argument.”

She laughed.

“What are you getting?”

“Apparently, whatever survives your approval.”

She gave him a look.

“Choose something!”

“I am trying.”

They continued through the menu.

He had imagined this part of the evening rather differently.

During the week, he had pictured them trying something unusual, perhaps ordering dishes neither had eaten before. It had seemed appropriate for a special occasion, as though an unfamiliar meal might help distinguish the evening from all the others.

Sanondita stopped turning the pages.

“I think I’ll have biryani.”

Utkarsh looked at her.

“Biryani?”

“Yes.”

He glanced at the menu.

Then back at her.

“After all that?”

“What?”

“We examined half the world’s cuisine.”

“So?”

“And we’ve arrived at biryani.”

She began laughing.

“I want biryani!”

“Of course.”

“What’s wrong with biryani?”

“Nothing. It’s a very respectable conclusion to an international investigation.”

She laughed harder.

He looked at her, then at the menu.

Biryani had never been his first choice. He enjoyed it well enough, but there were other dishes he would ordinarily have preferred.

He considered suggesting something else.

Then he closed the menu.

“Fine. Biryani.”

She looked at him.

“You don’t have to order the same thing.”

“I know.”

“Then order whatever you want.”

He smiled.

“I want dinner.”

“That is not a dish!”

“It should be.”

She shook her head.

He opened the menu once more, made a brief show of considering the alternatives, and then ordered biryani as well.

He was hungry. Biryani would do perfectly well, however much of the menu they had examined to arrive at it.

The waiter took their order.

Before leaving, he offered a word of caution.

“The biryani is quite spicy.”

Sanondita looked up.

“That’s fine.”

“Are you sure?” Utkarsh asked.

She turned towards him.

“I like spicy food.”

“I know.”

“Then?”

“Nothing. I merely wanted the warning entered into the official record.”

The waiter smiled.

Sanondita laughed.

“Don’t listen to him.”

Utkarsh looked at the waiter.

“You’ve heard both sides.”

The waiter, still smiling, assured them that their order would be served shortly.

When he left, Sanondita turned towards Utkarsh.

“You’re impossible.”

“So I’ve been told.”

“By whom?”

“Several reliable sources.”

She laughed.

He looked towards the Christmas tree.

“Before the food comes, shall we take some photographs?”

Her expression brightened.

“Yes!”

She reached for her phone.

He stood.

“Come on.”

They walked towards the decorated corner of the restaurant.

The Christmas tree stood beneath a cluster of warm lights, its branches adorned with red ornaments, small golden decorations, and delicate strands that caught the light whenever someone passed.

Sanondita stopped beside it, holding the bouquet.

Utkarsh took her phone.

“Stand there.”

She moved slightly.

“Here?”
“A little to your right.”
She moved.
“No, your other right.”
She turned towards him.
“Utkarsh!”
He laughed.
“Sorry. That one was my fault.”
She adjusted her position.
He raised the phone.
“Look here.”
She did.
He took a photograph.
Then another.
He lowered the phone to examine them.
“Hmm.”
“What?”
“The lighting is good.”
“Then?”
“Stand a little closer to the tree.”
She moved.
He took two more.
“Show me.”
He handed her the phone.
She examined the photographs.
“This one is nice.”
He leaned towards the screen.
“Yes.”
“But I don’t like that one.”
“Why?”
“My expression.”
He looked at the photograph.
It seemed perfectly good to him.

“You look fine.”

“No.”

“It’s a nice photograph.”

“No, take another.”

He accepted the phone.

“Of course.”

She returned to her position.

He adjusted the angle.

“Turn a little.”

“Like this?”

“Yes.”

He took another photograph.

She came back to inspect it.

“Better.”

“Excellent. The photographer’s employment has been extended.”

She laughed.

They tried another pose.

He suggested that she hold the bouquet slightly lower so the roses would be visible without covering her face.

She attempted it, looked at the result, and rejected the photograph immediately.

“No.”

“What now?”

“I don’t like how I’m standing.”

He studied the picture.

“What’s wrong with it?”

“Everything.”

“That’s a very comprehensive review.”

“Take another.”

He did.

Then another.

At one point, he crouched slightly to change the angle.

Sanondita looked down at him.

“What are you doing?”

“Trying to improve the composition.”

“You look ridiculous.”

“Great art requires sacrifice.”

She laughed so suddenly that he took the photograph before she was ready.

When he showed it to her, she laughed again.

“Delete that!”

“Why? You’re laughing.”

“Exactly!”

“It’s a good one.”

“No!”

He deleted it.

Or rather, he pretended for a moment to be considering whether such an important artistic work should be destroyed, until she threatened to take the phone away.

Then he deleted it.

He took another.

And another.

Gradually, they found a few she liked.

Utkarsh did not mind the repeated attempts.

He liked watching her examine the photographs, reject some, reconsider others, and smile when she found one that pleased her.

By the time she approved the photographs, he had forgotten which pose he had originally suggested. She handed back the phone to show him one more. He took it, still smiling.

“Now one together,” he said.

She nodded.

He returned her phone and moved beside her.

They stood near the Christmas tree, the bouquet between them.

He raised his own phone for a selfie.

His height immediately became a problem.

“Come closer,” he said.

“I am close!”

“Then I’m too tall.”

“That’s not something you can fix right now.”

“An unfortunate design flaw.”

She laughed.

He lowered the phone.

“Better?”

“Yes.”

They took a photograph.

He examined it.

His face was too close to the edge.

He adjusted the angle and tried again.

This time, part of the Christmas tree disappeared behind his shoulder.

Sanondita looked at the screen.

“Why are you taking it like that?”

“Because the alternative is to remove my head.”

She laughed.

“Just bend a little!”

He did.

“Not that much!”

He straightened slightly.

“Please provide exact measurements.”

She shook her head, laughing.

Eventually, they managed a photograph that included both their faces, the bouquet, and enough of the decorated tree to establish where they had been.

It was not perfectly composed.

Utkarsh liked it.

He asked her to take another, just in case.

She obliged.

Then they returned to their table.

Their food had not yet arrived.

Sanondita began reviewing the photographs on her phone.

Utkarsh sat beside her.

Occasionally, she tilted the screen towards him.

“This one?”

“Good.”

“This?”

“Also good.”

“You’re saying everything is good.”

“Perhaps the photographer was exceptionally talented.”

She laughed.

“Or perhaps you’re not looking properly.”

“That is also possible.”

She returned to the photographs.

He watched the screen for a moment.

There she was, standing beneath the Christmas decorations, holding the roses he had spent so long choosing.

There they were together, smiling into a camera in a restaurant they had selected almost by accident.

He had wanted photographs.

He could no longer recall the words of whole conversations from coaching. Some afternoons survived only as the certainty that he had enjoyed them. Here, at least, were their faces, the bouquet, the place they had chosen.

Yet as Sanondita scrolled through the photographs, he found himself thinking that the images would never contain the parts he most wished to preserve.

They would not record her objection to Marriott.

They would not capture the way she had laughed when he described the restaurant search as an international investigation.

They would not show how naturally she had moved to the stool beside him, or how carefully she had carried the bouquet throughout the evening.

They would preserve their faces.

The rest would depend upon him.

“Utkarsh?”

He looked up.

“Hmm?”

“Look at this one.”

She showed him another photograph.

It was the selfie they had taken near the tree.

Her smile was bright. His expression was slightly awkward, as though he had been concentrating too hard on keeping both of them inside the frame.

He laughed.

“What?”

“Nothing. I look very serious.”

“You always look serious in photographs.”

“That’s because I’m performing a difficult task.”

“What task?”

“Trying to look normal.”

She laughed.

He looked at the photograph again.

He was glad they had taken it.

He was glad she had asked for another whenever she disliked one.

He was glad that, for a little while, their greatest concern had been whether the angle was flattering and whether the Christmas tree could be seen behind them.

The waiter approached with their food.

The aroma reached them before the plates were placed on the table.

Sanondita looked delighted.

Utkarsh thanked the waiter.

For a moment, both examined the biryani.

It looked excellent.

It also looked considerably more dangerous than either had expected.

Utkarsh glanced at her.

“Remember the warning?”

She picked up her spoon.
“I told you. I like spicy food.”
“Very well.”
She took a bite.
He watched her expression.
At first, nothing happened.
She chewed thoughtfully.
Then she reached for her water.
Utkarsh looked at her.
“Everything all right?”
She nodded.
“Yes.”
He took a bite of his own.
The heat arrived almost immediately.
He stopped chewing for a second.
Then continued with what he hoped was dignity.
Sanondita looked at him.
“Spicy?”
“A little.”
She laughed.
“A little?”
He reached for his water.
“Perhaps moderately.”
She took another bite.
For a few seconds, they ate in silence.
Then Sanondita blinked.
Her eyes had begun to water.
Utkarsh noticed.
He tried not to smile.
She noticed him noticing.
“What?”
“Nothing.”
“Don’t laugh!”

“I’m not laughing.”

“You are!”

He looked down at his plate.

That made it worse.

His shoulders moved.

She began laughing too, though the spice had apparently made laughing an inconvenient activity.

“This one’s way spicier!”

He looked up.

“Than what?”

“Than I expected!”

“I believe someone warned us.”

She reached for her water again.

“Stop!”

“I said nothing.”

“You’re smiling!”

“I’m remembering the official record.”

She laughed, then shook her head.

He took another bite.

It was genuinely spicy.

He could no longer pretend otherwise.

For a moment, they were both occupied with managing the consequences of their decision.

Sanondita drank some water.

Utkarsh followed.

She looked at him.

“Why did you order the same thing?”

He considered the question.

“Solidarity.”

She laughed.

“Now suffer.”

“I am.”

“Good.”

He smiled.

They continued eating.

The restaurant carried on around them. Waiters moved between tables, conversations rose and fell beneath the greenery, and the Christmas lights glowed warmly against the glass.

Utkarsh had imagined a more elaborate dinner.

He had pictured unfamiliar dishes, carefully chosen courses, perhaps a conversation that would become important enough to remember word for word.

Instead, they were eating biryani that was too spicy, teasing each other, and occasionally reaching for their water glasses at almost the same moment.

He could not remember the last time he had felt so entirely at ease.

He reached for his water at the same time she reached for hers. She caught his eye and laughed before either had said anything.

He looked at her.

She was telling him something between bites, pausing occasionally to complain about the spice before continuing as though nothing had happened.

He listened.

He laughed when she expected him to laugh.

He answered when she asked him something.

And somewhere between the conversation, the photographs, and the unexpectedly fierce biryani, he realised that he had stopped waiting for the perfect moment.

Not because he had forgotten what he wanted to say.

Not because the words had become less important.

But because, for the first time, he was beginning to fear what might happen to the evening if he said them.

He had come prepared to confess a feeling that had survived nearly two years.

He had imagined that speaking it would honour everything he had kept hidden.

Now he watched her laughing and hesitated. If he spoke, would she grow careful with him? Would he have to watch her choose an answer? He could not know. The possibility was enough to keep him occupied with his plate.

The bouquet rested beside her, its roses catching the warm light.

He wanted her to finish her dinner as easily as she had begun it. He wanted another moment in which he did not have to find out what speaking would change.

So he asked her another question.

She answered.

He made a joke.

She laughed.

And the conversation continued, warm and ordinary, while outside the glass wall the December night gathered around the city.

For a little while longer, he could follow the conversation without looking at the time.

Sanondita's phone began ringing before they had finished dinner.

She glanced at the screen.

"Didum."

Utkarsh looked up.

"Your grandmother?"

She nodded and answered.

He returned his attention to his plate, giving her what privacy he could in a restaurant where they were sitting only inches apart.

Her voice softened as she spoke.

"Yes, Didum. I'm eating."

A pause.

"No, I'm still outside."

Another pause.

"I know."

Utkarsh smiled faintly at his plate.

He could not hear the other end of the conversation, but he understood enough. The hour was growing late, and somewhere

beyond the restaurant's warm lights, someone was waiting for Sanondita to come home.

She ended the call and placed her phone on the table.

"What happened?" he asked.

"She's asking when I'll return."

"What did you tell her?"

"That I'm having dinner."

"A perfectly accurate statement."

"She wants me to come home soon."

He glanced at the time.

It was later than he had realised.

"Then we shouldn't delay too much."

Sanondita nodded.

They continued eating.

For a little while, the conversation returned to the food. The biryani remained determinedly spicy, and Utkarsh made the mistake of reaching for his water just as Sanondita was preparing to tease him about his earlier confidence.

She laughed.

He looked at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Now you're doing it."

"Doing what?"

"Saying nothing when you clearly mean something."

She smiled.

"Learned from you."

He could hardly dispute that.

He looked down at his plate, smiling to himself.

It occurred to him that there were habits people acquired from one another without ever noticing. Small expressions, familiar jokes, particular ways of responding to a question. He wondered how many of his own had changed during the time he had known her.

Perhaps more than he realised.

Perhaps some would remain long after the conversations that had given rise to them were forgotten.

Her phone rang again.

She glanced at the screen and sighed.

“Didum again.”

“Answer it.”

She did.

This conversation was shorter.

When she ended the call, she looked at the time.

“I really should go.”

Utkarsh nodded.

“Yes.”

He said it easily.

Too easily.

For a moment, he almost believed himself.

They finished what remained of their dinner, and he asked for the bill.

While they waited, Sanondita looked through the photographs they had taken near the Christmas tree.

She showed him one she particularly liked.

He agreed that it was good.

Then she showed him another.

He made some unnecessary remark about his own expression, and she laughed.

The waiter brought the bill.

Utkarsh paid.

Sanondita thanked him.

He told her not to make a formal occasion of it.

She replied that he had been the one behaving formally all evening.

He protested.

She reminded him of the restaurant-selection committee.

He conceded that the evidence against him was substantial.

And so, with the same unremarkable conversation that had carried them through the afternoon, they prepared to leave.

Utkarsh collected his jacket.

Sanondita gathered her purse, her phone, and the bouquet.

They walked towards the entrance.

He held the door open for her.

Outside, Kolkata had become cold.

Not the severe cold of northern winters, but the damp, persistent chill that December sometimes brought to the city after dark. It settled against the skin and gathered beneath collars, making the warmth of an indoor room seem more distant with every passing minute.

The streetlights cast a soft yellow glow across the pavement.

A faint mist hung in the air.

Vehicles moved along the road, their headlights appearing brighter against the darkness. Somewhere nearby, a motorcycle engine started, and a man standing beside a parked car spoke into his phone.

Sanondita checked the time.

“I should book a ride.”

Utkarsh looked at her.

“Already?”

She gave him an incredulous look.

“Utkarsh, it’s late!”

“I know.”

“Didum has called twice.”

“I know.”

She opened the Rapido app.

He watched her for a moment.

Then he said, “Sanondita?”

“Hmm?”

“Can we walk for ten minutes?”

She looked up.

“Now?”

“Yes.”

“It’s too late.”

“Just ten minutes.”

“No, I really have to go.”

He nodded.

He knew she was right.

He had known it before asking.

Still, the words came again.

“Five minutes, then?”

She looked at him.

“Five?”

“Only five.”

He had no destination to offer her, nothing that required a walk. He wanted five minutes because he could not bear asking for everything he meant by them.

Sanondita glanced towards the road.

“We can sit for a bit,” she said. “But I have to book my ride.”

He nodded.

“Of course.”

She completed the booking.

A motorcycle was approximately ten minutes away.

“Ten minutes,” she told him.

He looked at her phone.

Ten minutes.

The estimate sat beneath the rider’s name. He watched it for a moment, hoping it would increase. She had already said she needed to go.

Still, another minute.

Perhaps two.

He was ashamed of how quickly he began making such calculations.

There were a few chairs outside the lounge, arranged beneath the warm light near the entrance.

They sat.

Sanondita settled into one, placing the bouquet carefully against her arm.

Utkarsh took the chair beside her.

His jacket remained folded across his lap.

For a moment, he looked at their surroundings.

The restaurant's windows glowed behind them. Beyond the pavement, headlights moved through the mist. A faint breeze stirred the leaves of a nearby plant, and the yellow light fell across Sanondita's face in a way that reminded him of the bench beside the lake.

He had wanted five more minutes.

Now he had them.

He did not know what to do with them.

He asked whether she had enjoyed the food.

She said yes, although it had been much spicier than she expected.

He reminded her that the waiter had warned them.

She told him to stop mentioning the waiter.

He laughed.

She laughed too.

Then the conversation paused.

Utkarsh looked towards the road.

He could feel the words waiting.

They had been with him since before the seventh of December, when he had invited her to Eco Park. In truth, they had been with him far longer than that.

He had imagined speaking them while walking beside the lake.

Then beneath the illuminated Eiffel Tower.

Then on the bench.

Then after dinner.

And now dinner was over.

The park had closed.

The restaurant was behind them.

There was no other destination left in the evening.

He looked at Sanondita.

She was checking her phone.

The motorcycle was approaching.

He could have told her.

He could have said that he had loved her for nearly two years, that the affection had begun in a classroom and survived the disappearance of almost everything that had once made their meetings ordinary.

He could have told her that he was not asking for anything.

That he knew her life belonged to her.

That he understood the difference between being loved and being treated kindly, and that he had long since stopped confusing the two.

He could have told her that knowing her had made a difficult period of his life gentler than it might otherwise have been.

Perhaps she would have listened.

Perhaps she would have been surprised.

Perhaps she would have said something kind, something careful, something that neither of them would ever entirely forget.

He had no way of knowing.

He feared the conversation would change. She might be kind; she might be uncomfortable; she might understand more than he expected. He would have to remain beside her while she answered, unable to take the words back.

She had been his friend. He had loved her. Sitting beside her now, he could not find a way to say the second without fearing that she would question the first.

He looked down at his hands.

For a moment, he thought of the letter he had never written.

Then of the words he had written and discarded.

Then of the birthday note he had once folded into a gift, hoping that something of his feelings might be understood without his having to explain them.

He had spent so long searching for the perfect way to speak that silence had gradually become the language he knew best.

He could not tell whether he was protecting her evening or protecting himself from the vulnerability of being understood.

Perhaps both.

He looked at her phone, then away. Whatever he called the choice, he was still making it. The words remained with him.

“Utkarsh?”

He looked up.

“Hmm?”

“Can you take a few more pictures?”

She held out her phone.

He accepted it.

“Of course.”

She stood near the chairs, the bouquet in her hands.

He stepped back.

The light was not ideal.

It fell unevenly across the pavement, and the darkness behind her made the phone struggle to find the right exposure.

“Stand a little this way,” he said.

She moved.

“Here?”

“Yes.”

He took a photograph.

Then another.

She came closer to examine them.

“This one’s dark.”

“I know.”

“Try again.”

He nodded.

She returned to her place.

He adjusted the angle.

A passing vehicle briefly illuminated the road behind her.

He waited for it to move away.

Then he took another photograph.

“Better,” he said.

She looked.

“Yes. This one’s nice.”

He handed back the phone.

She examined the picture for another moment.

Then she looked at him.

“Should I take one of you?”

He shook his head.

“No.”

“Why?”

“It’s fine.”

“You don’t want one?”

“No.”

She looked mildly puzzled.

Then she put the phone away.

He did not explain.

He had never particularly enjoyed being photographed.

But that was not the whole reason.

He had spent the evening wanting to remember her as she was—laughing beside the lake, carrying flowers, examining menus, complaining about photographs, insisting that she could manage spicy food.

He had not once wondered whether he himself would look worth remembering.

It was an unfair thought.

Perhaps she would have liked a photograph of him.

Perhaps she had offered simply because he had taken so many of her.

He could not know.

He had refused before considering why. She put the phone away, and he let the opportunity pass.

Sanondita checked her phone.

"It's almost here."

Utkarsh nodded.

He took out his own phone and opened Rapido.

He had to return home as well.

He entered his destination and booked a motorcycle.

The estimate appeared.

Fifteen minutes.

He stared at the number.

Her ride would arrive first.

Of course it would.

He would still be here when she left. He looked at the chair she occupied, then put his phone away.

Sanondita looked towards the road.

"When you go home, call me once."

He turned towards her.

"What?"

"Call me when you reach home."

He looked at her for a moment.

Then nodded.

"Yes. I will."

She returned her attention to the approaching traffic.

He looked down.

She had said it without hesitation and was already looking for her ride. He glanced at his phone again. Later, when he reached his room, she would be expecting to hear from him. The thought steadied him for a moment. It also made leaving her harder.

He looked at her.

"Sanondita?"

She turned.

"Yes?"

He opened his mouth.

He could tell her he would miss her. The sentence was small enough to say here, without explaining everything that lay behind it.

She was looking at him, waiting.

Then a motorcycle slowed near the pavement.

Sanondita glanced towards the road.

“I think that’s mine.”

Utkarsh looked.

The rider checked his phone.

She checked the registration number.

It matched.

The moment was gone.

The motorcycle had arrived when the app said it would.

Sanondita stood.

Utkarsh stood with her.

She adjusted her purse and gathered the bouquet more securely against her arm.

The rider waited beside the motorcycle.

For a moment, Utkarsh considered offering to book her a cab instead.

Earlier, he had offered to accompany her home in a cab, but she had declined. Arriving with him and a large bouquet, she had explained, would invite questions she did not particularly wish to answer.

He had understood.

He understood now.

He left the offer unspoken. She had chosen her ride, and the rider was waiting.

“Everything okay?” he asked.

“Yes.”

She glanced at the rider, then at him.

He nodded.

There was nothing left to arrange.

No ticket to purchase.

No restaurant to choose.

No photograph to retake.

No route to check on her behalf.

He had spent the entire day finding small things to do because doing them was easier than facing the one thing he had come to say.

Now even those tasks were finished.

Sanondita moved towards the motorcycle.

Utkarsh remained near the chairs.

He watched her speak briefly to the rider.

She arranged the bouquet carefully so that it would not be crushed during the journey.

Then she put on the helmet.

He remembered her putting away her notebook after class, gathering her bag while he found a reason to linger. Back then, even if she did not come the next morning, there had been another class to expect her in.

He watched her settle the flowers against her arm.

Now he stood beneath the yellow light, watching her settle onto the motorcycle.

He wanted to call her name.

He wanted to ask for one more minute.

Not to confess.

Not anymore.

Only to hear her answer.

He imagined how she would turn towards him, perhaps impatiently, perhaps amused, and ask what he wanted.

He had no answer.

She had come. They had spent the afternoon together, and he had laughed more than he had expected to. Even now, the memory of her insisting she could manage the biryani almost made him smile.

The pain was not that the evening had failed him.

It was that it had been everything he could reasonably have wished for, and still he was not ready for it to end.

Sanondita adjusted the helmet.

Then, before the motorcycle moved, she turned towards him.

“Bye.”

He had heard her say it countless times. His mouth moved, but no answer came.

He did not say it back.

He did not say see you.

He stood beneath the streetlight, looking at her.

Perhaps she did not notice his silence.

Perhaps the traffic was too loud, or perhaps she assumed he had answered.

He would never know.

The rider started the motorcycle.

It moved away from the pavement.

Utkarsh watched.

At first, he could still distinguish the bouquet against her arm, its black wrapping almost invisible in the darkness.

Then the motorcycle passed beneath another streetlight.

For a brief instant, the red roses caught the glow.

He could see her sitting behind the rider, the helmet turned towards the road ahead.

She did not look back.

There was no reason she should.

The motorcycle continued down the street.

Its rear light grew smaller.

A car passed between them.

When it moved away, he found the motorcycle again.

Farther now.

The mist was thicker beyond the nearest streetlights.

He watched the red light move towards it.

He had come with so much to tell her. She had given him one word to answer, and he had let her leave without it.

The motorcycle moved farther away.

Its rear light trembled briefly through the mist.

He kept watching.

He knew the road would continue beyond what he could see.

He knew she would reach home, take off the helmet, carry the flowers inside, and return to the life that was hers.

He hoped she would be happy.

The thought was simple.

It did not make the moment easier.

On the first morning, she had asked someone else a question and he had answered before he could stop himself.

He remembered how easily the words had come then.

The red light moved beyond the next crossing. He leaned forward slightly, trying to keep it in view.

The motorcycle's light became a faint red point.

Then the mist swallowed it.

Utkarsh remained where he was.

He looked towards the place where she had disappeared.

The road was still there.

Vehicles continued passing.

Somewhere behind him, the restaurant door opened, releasing a brief murmur of voices and warmth before closing again.

His phone rested in his pocket.

His own ride had not yet arrived.

The December air moved quietly around him.

He could have looked away.

He could have checked the time, opened the app, or turned towards the chairs where they had been sitting only minutes earlier.

Instead, he kept his eyes on the empty stretch of road.

There had been so many days when he had left her believing there would be another chance to speak.

Another morning.

Another walk.

Another evening.

He had always thought the difficulty lay in finding the right moment.

Only now did he understand that the moments had never been waiting for him to become ready.

They had simply been passing.

And somewhere in that December night, a part of him would remain forever—standing beneath the fading yellow light, watching the winter fog take her away, and waiting for one last glimpse of someone who was already gone.